The Qur'an: A Short Introduction

Orientation for first-time readers

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What the Qur'an is

The Qur'an is the central religious text of Islam, regarded by Muslims as the word of God revealed to the Prophet Muhammad over a period of about twenty-three years, beginning in the early seventh century.

How the text is arranged

The Qur'an contains 114 chapters, called surahs, which vary greatly in length. Surahs are composed of verses (ayat). For reading over a month, the text is also divided into thirty parts of roughly equal length (ajza', singular juz').

Surahs are traditionally described as Makki (revealed in Mecca) or Madani (revealed in Medina). Makki surahs tend to focus on faith, the afterlife, and the stories of earlier prophets; Madani surahs address communal life, law, and the growing Muslim community — though both themes appear in both periods.

Surahs are arranged roughly by length rather than chronology: the longest generally stand near the beginning of the book, the shortest near its end. The opening surah, al-Fatihah, is recited in every unit of Muslim prayer.

Language and recitation

The Qur'an is in Arabic, and Muslims regard the Arabic wording itself as revelation — translations are treated as meanings of the text rather than as the text itself. A discipline called tajwid governs correct pronunciation and melody in recitation, and memorisation of the entire text remains common throughout the Muslim world.

Reading recommendations

New readers often start with a reliable translation alongside the opening surah and the shorter surahs at the end of the book. A good commentary (tafsir) helps with context, and knowledgeable readers in one's community can help with questions.

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